

When and How Do I Open a Bank Account?

If you have a few hundred dollars saved from birthday cards, part-time jobs, or not giving your parents their change back when they send you to get groceries, you should open a bank account. Putting your money into a bank is going to keep it safe and organized, and potentially help it grow.

Before you open an account, the bank is going to see if you are qualified, which most people are. Things that could disqualify you would be a criminal history of bank-related crimes, or if you have had accounts in the past that you left in a large negative balance.⁹ Once you have been qualified, you will need a government-issued ID, Social Security card, and proof of address to open an account. A government-issued ID can be a passport, valid driver's license, or state ID. If you do not have any of these, you can take your birth certificate and Social Security card to your local DMV to get a state-issued ID. If you are under 18, you will also need an adult over the age of 18 to be on the account with you. An account that is shared by two people is called a **joint account**.

A joint account is a great option if you are under 18 because it gives you a true banking experience and allows you to build your money-management skills. On a joint account, both individuals can make deposits and withdrawals and monitor the account's activity. You need to be sure you trust the person you share an account with. There are countless stories of people who had their joint account emptied by their parents or whoever they shared it with. In this kind of situation, it is hard to get your money back

⁹ Greg Depersio, "What to Bring to a Bank to Open a Checking Account," Investopedia, February 22, 2020, <https://www.investopedia.com/ask/answers/040715/what-should-you-bring-bank-open-checking-account.asp>.